

Teaching Discussion

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Overview

- I need to teach morphosyntax
- I taught a little morphosyntax and a lot of HPSG last year (Sag, Wasow and Bender).
 - ▶ Most of the students gave positive feedback in the last class
 - ▶ One (anonymous) feedback “**this is a complete waste of time**” we had a very hard group of students (‘their eyes are dead’)
- Should I keep teaching HPSG? and if so, how can I make it more accessible
- We have three strands
 - ▶ General Linguistics (a lot of semiotics, discourse analysis, history of linguistics)
 - ▶ Linguistics and Digital Humanities (some NLP, corpus linguistics, Zipf’s law)
 - ▶ Linguistic Analyst (a lot of NLP, machine learning, network analysis — professional course)



Current Syllabus

- ➊ Introduction to Morpho-Syntax
- ➋ Some Simple Theories of Grammar and Morphology
- ➌ Feature Structures
- ➍ Complex Feature Structures
- ➎ Semantics & How the Grammar Works
- ➏ Binding
- ➐ The Structure of the Lexicon: (Types; Rules)
- ➑ Realistic Grammar
- ➒ Dummies and Idioms (Passives)
- ➓ Raising and Control
- ➔ Long Distance Dependencies
- ➕ Sign-based Construction Grammar



Alternative Syllabus

- 1 Word structure
- 2 Morphological units and categories
- 3 Methods of description of sentence structure
- 4 Parts of speech versus syntactic functions
- 5 Syntactic relations
- 6 Transitivity
- 7 Morphology and valence
- 8 Morphology and syntax in language typology
- 9 Sentence centrality; total rate of sentence dependence, depth and breadth of dependence
- 10 Effect of frequency on morphology and syntax



Pros and cons for me teaching HPSG

- Pro

- ▶ I know HPSG
- ▶ I think it is a good way of modelling syntax (although not the only one)
- ▶ We have a good textbook
- ▶ We have a computational model

- Cons

- ▶ HPSG is an endangered formalism
- ▶ The text book is a little hard for non-English speakers
 - ★ Even for Singlish students, they often disagreed with the judgements
 - ★ Czech students just can't make many of them (binding and passive)

- The students are unlikely to become grammarians
- There are not many Czech analyses in the literature



How I frame it

On completion of this module, students should be able to:

- Understand the basics of morphology
- Recognize certain classes of syntactic phenomena
- Build analyses of those phenomena in a precise framework
- Apply the process of building a formalized analysis to test linguistic hypotheses
- Know a little about different approaches to the study of syntax
- Be able to present linguistics using LaTeX (a useful skill)

We learn how to model and test hypotheses
more than learning syntax



What I would like

- A simpler/shorter textbook
- Some more basic discussion: pos vs function, more about frequency, ...
- More Slavic examples
 - ▶ I will try to build up some, but I am not a native speaker
 - ▶ Maybe some contrastive examples (like impersonal adverbs)
 - ▶ Second position scares me
- More surety that they are learning something useful
I don't want to waste their time/energy

What I worry about

- I used to teach both HPSG and Grammar Engineering
— don't think there is enough interest now
- I also teach semantics, where we at refer back to syntax a little
- But for them syntax is sort of a dead end — they don't build on it

